

“Their object was [kabbalistic] magic: occult wisdom ... from the beginning of the world, and matured by Christ.”

THOMAS DE QUINCEY, ON FREEMASONS IN *SUSPIRIA DE PROFUNDIS*, c. 1824



Universal truths and symbols

Freemasonry draws on a body of semi-mystical, magical teachings and beliefs. It venerates a Supreme Being, the Great Architect of the Universe, but it is not a religion. Like alchemy, Hermeticism, and Rosicrucianism, its concern is the search for a universal truth. Symbolism and ritual are used to unlock the truth. The most important symbol of all is the Temple of Solomon, built in Jerusalem in c. 960 BCE, because its architect, Hiram Abiff, was deemed to be the first Mason.

Freemasons pay homage to the All-Seeing Eye of God and the Blazing Star, variously claimed as the sun, Venus, or the Star of Bethlehem. The mystagogue, Hermes Trismegistus (see pp.134–135), who is said to have kept intact the secrets of geometry, is also revered. The tools of the medieval Masons—the square, compass, and apron—pay tribute to their exacting geometrical demands and are consistent symbols of Freemasonry.

Legendary past

Freemasons liked to construct their own traditions to give gravitas to their movement. For example, they claimed that the 10th-century Anglo-Saxon king, Athelstan, introduced the biblical teachings of Moses and Noah, and of Euclid, the 4th-century BCE “father of geometry,” to England, and that the Knights Templar (12th-century Crusaders; see pp.118–119) were champions of Freemasonry. This mix of invention and secrecy contributed to a quasi-mystical aura—for those initiated into the highest orders, contemplation of the truth was said to produce a transcendent wonder.

◀ Masonic tracing board

Tracing boards showed what the emblems and symbols of Freemasonry looked like, and were used to instruct new members in each degree of initiation. This stylized representation from 1819 of Solomon’s Temple under the All-Seeing Eye of God is flanked by the Two Pillars, Jachin and Boaz, which stood at the entrance.